the way our relentless working methods put the softly-softly approach that he favoured in the shade.

To our emerging critics, we were primitive. But in my mind, we were not primitive enough. You have to get over your own need for reassurance and resist the comfort zone of knowing you're only doing what others have done or are doing around you. Innovation can't work with that. We would certainly make mistakes, but even our mistakes would be honest if we resisted the temptation to shy away from danger. To me, a great number of those working for liberal causes are not only shy but borderline collusive. They want change to happen nicely, and it won't. They want decency to come about without anybody suffering or being embarrassed, and it won't. And most of all they want to give many of the enemies of open government the benefit of the doubt, and I don't. It's not just a difference of approach, it's a complete schism in our respective philosophy. You can't go about disclosure in the hope that it won't spoil anybody's dinner.

My travels in Africa also took me to Cairo. An American contact we had made in Kenya invited us to share the place she was staying in, a house that belonged to a former Miss Egypt. It was a grand house, and there were several paintings of Miss Egypt on the walls, so it was an amusingly surreal place to stay. However, it was right next to the American embassy – there was a van full of soldiers permanently stationed near our front door – and I thought it might be easier to keep a low profile if I moved somewhere else. Together with a Korean girl I had also met in Kenya, I moved into an apartment near the Nile. It was an enormous, tall building and we were almost on the top floor; sometimes when the Cairo smog wasn't too bad we could see the Great Pyramids through the windows.

It was easy to sense the tension under the surface in Egypt. There were always lots of police on the streets and there was an air of controlled confrontation, particularly in the centre and near to government buildings. But the great changes we have seen recently were still four years away, and like many people I didn't see them coming. Cairo had an influence on me in more emotional ways, I suppose. Being in that teeming metropolis of the rapidly developing world validated my sense that, to have a true impact, WikiLeaks would have to be an organisation with global reach.

I soon felt a great affection for Cairo. I enjoyed the bustle and the activity of the streets, the cafés, the Shisha in the evening. On the roof of an apartment building near me a family kept a tiny city farm. Every morning